sculpture of Lord Vishnu as half-lion and half-man (unlike the Egyptian sphinx, it has the head of a lion and the body of a man). Given that the Vijayanagar empire was known as Narsinga by the early Europeans, this sculpture is particularly appropriate.

As already mentioned, the ruins of Vijayanagar are located right across the Tungabhadra from Kishkindha and it is worthwhile crossing the river to visit it. Although a modern bridge was almost complete at the time of writing,[13] when I visited the site in 2007 and 2008, one still has to cross the Tungabhadra in a round coracle boat piled with people, goats, motor-cycles and sacks of rice. Almost five hundred years earlier, Domingo Paes made the same crossing and wrote, 'People cross to this place in boats which are round like baskets; inside, they are made of cane and outside, are covered with leather; they are able to carry fifteen or twenty people and even horses and oxen can use them if necessary but for the most part these animals swim across. Men row them with a sort of paddle, and the boats are always turning around.'[14] I know exactly what he meant.

In 1565, Vijayanagar was attacked by a grand alliance of all the Muslim kings of the Deccan. After being defeated in the Battle of Talikota on 26 January, the Vijayanagar army withdrew instead of defending the capital. It is said that the great city was plundered for six months. It never recovered. Vijayanagar can be considered the last flash of the 'classical' phase of Hindu civilization. The second cycle of India's urbanization had begun on the banks of the Ganga but ended on the banks of the Tungabhadra.

THE CITY OF THE KING OF THE WORLD

By the late 1500s, the Portuguese and the Spanish had competition from rival European nations. In the autumn of 1580, Francis Drake returned to London after his circumnavigation of the globe. By 1588, the English had decisively defeated the Spanish Armada. However, it was the Dutch who first took on the Portuguese in the Indian Ocean. The Dutch, only recently free from Iberian rule, set up the United East India Company in 1602. It was the world's first company to issue common stock and would grow into